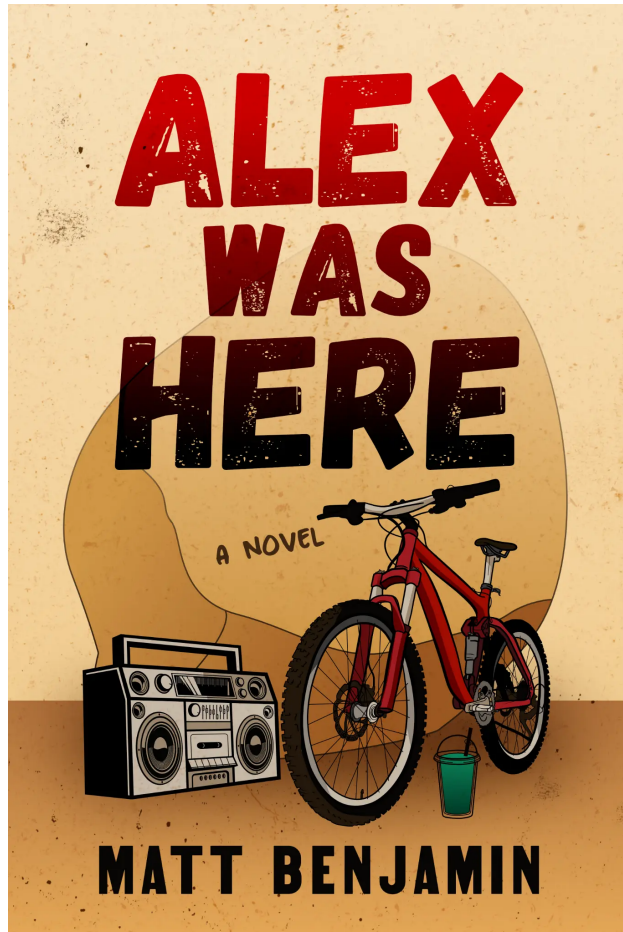




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Chapter One: Summer Undefined

Matt Benjamin

SUMMER UNDEFINED

When I moved to Long Island in January, life didn't change much. My dad got a new job. We found a new church. I said goodbye to my friends at string ensemble. But when you're homeschooled, a lot of things remain the same.

A few friends and I promised to stay in touch. But none of us did.

I think we were supposed to be excited about the move. It was a great job for my dad, and it let us move into a house much bigger than the one we came from. But I felt kind of indifferent.

The movers brought that big oak table from one kitchen to another. I sat at it for breakfast, then again to do schoolwork. My room in the new house was a different color, but the furniture was in all the same places: a little desk, a bed, a lamp—which I didn't need anymore, thanks to the overhead lights. It was a new home. A bigger home. But it was the same home.

And while the winter wasn't as cold as I was used to, it was still winter. There wasn't much to do. We spent months inside doing school, practicing viola, and wondering if things would feel different when the weather warmed up.

It wasn't until May that I realized they might.

We sat around the dinner table, finishing up our plates, when my dad cleared his throat.

"Nathan," he began, a strange look on his face.

My stomach tightened.

"Since we've moved, things have been a little more expensive than they were back in Pennsylvania," he said. "We expected that, of course. And the new job's been great. But we could use a little extra money. So, your mother and I decided she'd get a job this summer to help us balance the budget a little."

Maybe I made a face, or my confusion showed.

"Oh, don't worry, we have plenty of money," he added quickly. "We're not in financial trouble. It's just... it would be helpful."

My mom had never worked outside the home since I'd been born. She was always home. But I was fifteen. This shouldn't be a problem.

Maybe dad wanted me to get a job. Was this his way of suggesting something?

"Dad, I can get a job if you'd like," I offered.

He smiled and shook his head. “We thought about that,” he said. “But without reliable transportation, I don’t think it will work. We appreciate it, though. I just want to make sure you’ll be okay here alone during the day.”

I shrugged. “I’ll be fine.”

“Now, if you’d like to help, there are things you could do around the house to keep things up while your mother’s gone.”

That wasn’t anything new. I’d been doing chores for as long as I could remember.

“No problem, Dad.”

“So, what’s the job?” I asked, turning to Mom.

“Oh, I’ll be working at the lab with your father,” she said. “Just a desk job, answering phone calls, taking care of office stuff. It won’t start until after our last day of school.”

The last day of school. It was coming up.

I never minded homeschooling, but if I had to name a perk, it was finishing the school year early. We usually ended before the last week of May, but with the move, we’d probably push into June a little. Still, that left a long summer break ahead.

“Well,” dad said, “I’m glad you understand. And I hope you’re not too bored around here this summer.”

It was a valid concern. But I was used to it. I’d find something to do.

We cleared the table, did the dishes, and mostly went our separate ways. My dad paged through the newspaper in his green upholstered chair. My mom did laundry. I went back to my room to read, or maybe watch a little TV. I was allowed an hour a day, limited to a small selection of channels. But I almost always saved it for the end of the day. Something to look forward to.

The last few days of school flew by. The weather grew warmer and brighter, and the grass got greener with each passing day. There was something different about the skies on Long Island. We weren’t close to the water, twenty minutes away in any direction. But something about the sky told you the ocean was out there. It looked bluer. Cleaner.

And there were other differences.

The land was flatter. The biggest hill in our neighborhood was smaller than the one that used to lead up to our driveway. The roads were wider. There was far less farmland.

All the jokes about moving to “the big city” turned out to be wrong. Where we lived on the island, the towns were small. In fact, the nearest McDonald’s was farther from our new house than it had been from the old one.

On the first day of summer vacation, I woke up to a silent house.

I got dressed and wandered into the kitchen. And, as expected, there was a note from my mom:

Dear Nathan,

I hope you slept well, and I trust you’re ready to have a great summer vacation.

I’m a little nervous about getting back to work. It’s been many years, but I think I’ll do okay.

Thank you for your willingness to step up and take care of some things around the house while I’m gone.

I’ve left a small list of chores. Please pay attention to the ones with specific times next to them.

We’ll be home a little after five.

If you need anything, call your dad’s work number.

As soon as I find out mine, I’ll let you know.

I love you very much.

Mom

Beneath that was the list:

Do the dishes.

Vacuum the floors.

Switch over the laundry. When it’s done, fold it and leave it on my bed.

Take the chicken out of the fridge at 4 p.m.

Preheat the oven at 4:45 to 350 degrees. I’ll take care of the rest.

See if you can start clearing out the garden in the backyard. I’m not sure if we’ll plant anything this year, but I don’t want it to get too messy.

That was it.

Those tasks were on top of reading and viola practice, but it didn’t seem like it would take too long. I had always liked to get the work done first.

So after a quick breakfast, toast and an egg, I got started. Everything went quickly, and I had most of it done before lunchtime.

I went into the kitchen and made a turkey sandwich. I stared at the white bread and the little depressions rising where my fingers had held it.

A wave of panic rolled over me.

It was the first day of summer, and I was already bored.

I didn't have any friends to call. Nothing on the calendar to look forward to. Every day would look like this if I didn't find something to do.

Suddenly, the garden in the backyard seemed a lot more appealing. But something in me pushed back. Surely gardening is not going to be the fun thing you do this summer.

But, if it wasn't, what was?

All I knew was—it wasn't going to be in this house.

I headed to the garage, the only part of the house we hadn't fully unpacked. Behind a stack of boxes, I found my bike. It wasn't anything special. A Walmart bike, heavy and in disrepair. But it gave me something to do.

I hardly rode it in Pennsylvania. The hills and narrow shoulders made it tough. There was almost nowhere to go that wasn't uphill. And sure, for every uphill there's a downhill, but the downhills happen a lot faster. I was always huffing up a steep incline and regretting the whole thing.

But here?

The roads were flat, wide, and built with shoulders meant for riding.

Extracting the bike from the pile, I was surprised it wasn't in worse shape. I pumped the tires, tightened the brakes, sprayed on some WD-40, and just like that, it was ready to go.

The only question was: Where?

My parents hadn't said to stay close, but that was probably the expectation. Still, it was all new to me. Near or far, I'd be seeing something I hadn't seen before.

Helmet on, I coasted down the driveway. As I turned onto Highwood Drive, I let out a breath as the warm air hit my face.

It felt like something.

I pedaled past houses, surprised by how quiet the streets were. But it made sense. People were at work, and kids were still in school. Longview district hadn't let out yet. I heard the buses rumble down the street earlier that morning.

I don't think I passed a single car.

The neighborhood wasn't complicated. Highwood ran for about half a mile before it met Easton. Turn left, and it curved back around to Highwood. Turn right, and you'd head toward the main road and the high school.

I'd taken the right turn plenty of times with my family—church, errands, food. But left? I hadn't seen it yet. So that's where I went.

The loop was under a mile, and I made it pretty quickly. But before long, the boredom crept back in.

I started thinking about other routes.

One thing I'd noticed on my rides was a sump halfway down Easton. We didn't have those in Pennsylvania. Where we had creeks and reservoirs, Long Island had sumps—big sand pits at the edge of neighborhoods where everything drained when it rained.

Usually they were fenced in, gated, locked with a padlock.

But the one on Easton? The gate was open, hanging ajar by a few feet. And a trail seemed to lead through the light brush and into the sump itself.

I wanted to see what was inside.

But I hesitated.

I couldn't quite bring myself to go in.

There was probably a No Trespassing sign somewhere. And even if there wasn't, the broken padlock on the ground was a pretty clear sign I wasn't supposed to be there.

I heard the school bus turning onto Easton, pulling my attention from the sump.

So, rather than explore the sump, like any other fifteen-year-old on summer vacation would have done, I turned around and pedaled home.

Back at the house, I dumped my bike in the garage and finished the last few things I had to do before my parents got home. I practiced my viola, then sat down to read.

Virgil's Aeneid. Next year's literature would cover Ancient Rome. So, I'd get a head start.

By 4:30, I preheated the oven, took a shower, changed clothes, and waited.

I heard the car doors outside and opened the front door as my parents arrived. My mom scanned my face with concern, maybe even guilt. She'd spent so many years at home, leaving for a full day must've felt like abandonment.

"Nathan, how'd your day go?" she asked as she climbed the concrete steps.

I smiled and nodded. "Everything was fine."

No reason to make her feel bad.

Most kids my age would think having your mom around all day ruined the fun. But I was still pretty inexperienced at this "having fun" thing.

Mom got dinner into the oven. Dad disappeared to shower and change. I sat at the kitchen table, flipping through the newspaper he'd be reading soon, not that I cared much about what was in it. It was just something to do.

"So, did you get to practice your viola today?" Mom asked.

"Yeah."

I practiced every day, even if I didn't have anything specific to prepare for. No ensembles, no lessons. Just something I was good at. And something that might help when it came time to think about college.

"The house looks nice," she said. "Thanks for everything you did."

"You're welcome," I replied, not looking up from the paper.

"What else did you do while we were gone?"

"Not too much. I read a little. Took my bike out."

She gave a little smile—maybe some relief. At least I hadn't just sat around.

"Where'd you go?"

"Oh, just around the neighborhood."

"Did you meet anybody?"

"No. School's still in."

I wasn't sure I wanted to meet anyone. But it was a good excuse for now.

"Well, I'm glad you had fun," she said.

"Thanks," I replied, even though I'd never actually said I did. Still, I was glad she thought so.

Dinner came and went. The evening unfolded as always. I watched my hour of TV. Read as the sun went down. Was in bed by nine.

As I lay there that night, a resolution settled in my mind:

Tomorrow I'm going to see what's in that sump.

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